regardless. She grabs the pistol, forcing it upwards as the other shots strike the bell in the bell tower. In pure desperation, the man turns around and shoves Orym out of the bell tower and into the raging river below.

"Okay, enough," Vilde breaks his grip on the pistol, gaining control. "We'll talk later." She whips the butt of the pepperbox into his head, knocking him out.

As the confrontation ends, Wang Lei, Mason, Thaisha and Hazel enter the bell tower gracefully.

"Now, now, what is this?" The paladin picks up the longarm - *Wrath* - and inspects it. Requiring two hands to wield, Wang Lei learns that the weapon has incredible range and stopping power, but can only take one ammunition at a time.



Vilde inspects the pepperbox pistol *Vengeance*. With a rotating chamber which could store six charges at a time, the rogue finds a thinner, more refined pistol.

"What happened here?" Hazel surveys the area.

Intelligence (Investigation) Check

On a successful DC **15** check, Hazel sees that this bell tower, formerly used as signal towers throughout Raya, has been repurposed into a base of some sort.

On a successful DC **20** check, Hazel sees a map with other bell towers marked as potential vantage points. She deduces that the assailant likely had a plan to move in between the towers so as to harrass people on the ground.

On a successful DC **25** check, Hazel also finds letters to the Sewn Sisters, in particular Widow Groat, who provided occult knowledge that facilitated his experimentation with alchemical components and rare metals. Having unlocked the secrets of controlled explosive force, this is the first man to have created, and deftly wield, the world's first firearms.

Hazel shares this with the group as the Party begins wrapping up their investigation. Hearing that the firearms were constructed as part of an occult deal, Wang Lei reaches out to his patron quietly in the hopes of more power.

Wisdom (Insight) Check

On a successful DC **15** check, Wang Lei feels the Child's reticence. He comes to the conclusion that the Gray Baby is reluctant to impart more power or knowledge, in particular with a task outstanding.

Live Deliciously

Raphael, Salazar, Wukong, Vorn, Claptrap and Ariadne arrive at a flooded, swampy shrine. The ruined edifice, shaped like an arrowhead, squats in the muddy water. Bushes and trees grow from its roof. At the pointed front of the building, steps ascend to a stone door caked in slime.

Salazar inspects the door, seeing that it is not magically secured.

"*Nangnang teaches us to serve only ourselves*," Wukong recites, translating the inscription above the shrine.

Vorn punches the door, but fails to open it.

"Okay, let's try something a little bit more graceful, shall we?" Ariadne offers. Producing a set of *Thieves' Tools,* she offers it to Wukong. "If you wouldn't mind?"

The simian unlocks the door with a quick *click*. As the door swings open, the paladin takes the lead, activating his *Truesight*.

You see that the torches in this room have all been snuffed out. The rooms here are filled with treasure: chests heaped with coins, polished amphorae, strings of pearls, and ornate pieces of armor. Set into the floor, in front of another set of heavy double doors, is a mosaic tile depicting a frog-like humanoid.

As you enter the threshold, grungs flush out of the darkness with tridents and pitchforks. They jab their tridents out, pointing it straight at all of you.



Wukong's *Ring of 72 Transformations* glow with golden light as he casts *Disguise Self*. Raphael, Salazar, Wukong, Ariadne, Claptrap and Vorn all shapeshift into grungs.

"Move in!" Wukong commands as the Party - now frogs - leap into action.

Grung Poison

Grung poison loses its potency 1 minute after being removed from a grung. A creature poisoned by a grung can suffer two effects in total. If grappled, the Player rolls a d6 to see the color of the grung that has Poisoned them.

Color	Effect
Green	The creature cannot move.
Blue	The creature's throat closes up and cannot speak.
Purple	The creature feels a desperate need to soak itself in liquid or mud. It cannot take actions or move except to do so or reach a body of liquid or mud.
Red	The creature is frightened of its allies.
Orange	The creature's reaction is slowed and cannot take Reactions or Bonus Actions.
Gold	The creature is Charmed and speaks Grung.

The grungs see through the simian's illusion. The warriors leap across Ariadne as they both stab with their daggers at the elven wizard, drawing blood. Chirring in unison, a deep guttural vibration thrums through the damp swamp air as the grungs' vocal sacs swell to twice the size of their heads. The low, mesmerising croak reverberates in the surrounding stone, stunning Raphael, Ariadne, Claptrap and Vorn.

Wukong swings his *Jingubang,* slamming one of the grungs attacking Ariadne. The paladin strikes with such force that the frog's eyes enlarge against its wishes momentarily as his entire body is compressed by unnatural force.

Wukong swings the *Jingubang*, hammering the grung harassing Ariadne. The overwhelming force of the strike violently flattens the creature's torso, forcing its eyes to bulge wildly against its head as its entire body buckles under the paladin's wrath.

Surging out of the darkness, a baby ankylosaurus roars with fury to defend their home. It swings its mighty tail club, catching the elven wizard square in the chest and knocking her prone.

Raising aloft their staff, the grung wildlings cast *Spike Growth* and *Plant Growth*. Plants covered in hard spikes and thorns erupt from the ground of the shrine, growing violently straight through the stoneblocks of the shrine.

Seizing the opportunity to attack the paladin, the grung warrior behind Wukong dives into the dark to hide.

Salazar pushes forward. The thorns dig deep into him as he tries to get to Ariadne but is unable to get past the chaotic tangle of choking branches. In a frustrated attempt, he casts *Fire Bolt,* blasting the grung warrior attacking Ariadne.

Claptrap casts *Bless* on Vorn, Wukong and Raphael as he stays out of the grung's range. Ariadne's eyes glow white as she vanishes in a cloud of mist, reappearing on the slimy steps with *Misty Step*. She casts *Sacred Flame,* but the spell fails to connect with the grungs attacking her.

Hurt, the grung dives into the thony plant, vanishing into the bushes to hide. With Ariadne moving out of range, the other grung warrior leaps at Wukong in a low, vicious arc, his dagger poised for the simian's throat.

"Look out!"

Salazar doesn't hesitate. He thrusts his hand forward, casting a golden, translucent shield of force to repel the attacking grung. "Expelliarmus!"

His wand slices through the air as the grung is knocked back by *Shield Another*. With a metallic *ping,* Salazar's *Disarming Charm* tears the dagger free from the grung's grip, spinning end-over-end. Gracefully, Salazar steps up catches the weapon effortlessly by the hilt with his freehand, bringing it down into a casual guard.

The disarmed grung warrior crashes hard into the dirt at Wukong's feet, stunned and empty-handed. Eager to defend its home, the grung warrior leaps up at Salazar, grappling the wizard. Poison creeps up on the wizard, who just quickly brush the venom off.

Recalibrating his senses, Vorn regains control. He slams a powerful foot to the ground, knocking most of the grungs prone. The powerful shockwave radiates out from the blast, striking almost everybody in the Party, but breaks the concentration of the wildlings. The spell fades as the undergrowth recedes into the cracks between the stonefloor.

Wukong swings at the prone grung, who tries to roll away to safety but meets the wall of the shrine. His quarterstaff glows with brilliant light as the *Divine Smite* spell sears the frogfolk.

The wildling stretches his hand out at his wounded compatriot, eager to cast *Cure Wounds* on his friend. As he does so, Raphael's *Crown of Thorns* glows with a dark malevolent purple as it sucks the spell right out of the air, empowering the sorcerer.

In pure desperation, the grungs croak together to stun the invaders. This time, the Party is prepared. Everybody covers their ears, with the exception of Raphael who is stunned again.

Even with a grung warrior clawing at his arm, Salazar does not flinch. With the power of his mind, the wizard telekinetically breaks the grung's grip and flings the helpless frogfolk off him. The disarmed grung warrior does not even hit the ground; Vorn's massive fist catches the warrior and squeezes tight, causing the grung to explode into a shower of blood and viscera.

Locking eyes on the heavily injured grung ahead, he channels a swift *Fire Bolt*. The burst of flame detonates upon contact, engulfing the amphibian in roaring fire. The frogfolk shrieks in agony, flailing helplessly as it tries to slap out the inferno consuming its skin. The poor grung collapses in a smoldering heap, its whimper cutting short as the sharp smell of charred frog fills the shrine.

Outside, Ariadne watches as seven other grung warriors break the surface of the swamp, their weapons drawn. Croaks ring out from this group, prompting replies from inside the shrine.

Vorn's attention whips around as the emotionless shield guardian regards the terrified grungs. His arms activate with devastating speed, unleashing a flurry of blows and pulverizing the grung wildling into a smear on the stonework.

The horrifying display of power leaves the remaining two grung warriors and one wildling in abject fear. They croak out in fear as Wukong rounds up on the wildling. With a powerful swing, the paladin crushes the skull of the grung and turns the living frogfolk into nothing but a stain on the stonework. The two remaining warriors drop to their knees, raising their weapons up with shaky heads in an act of submission.

"I'd like to formally make an application for the competition," Ariadne says, approaching Raphael. "It's not my best work, but here we go." She passes him a small parchment.

Raphael unfurls the note, inspecting it: *Croak and Dagger*. He laughs politely, "I'll consider it." The sorcerer's eyes glow purple as he casts *Detect Thoughts,* trying to discern the thoughts and emotions of the grungs. He receives nothing but terror from the grungs, who are still shivering with fright.

Salazar bends low, trying to charm the ankylosaurus.

"Forget about the dinosaur," Raphael says, rolling his eyes. "Let's get into the shrine."

"And the grungs?" Wukong asks.

"Let's just leave them be. We invaded their home, but I think if we just leave them after we're done it should be fine," Raphael explains. "Let's just get the cube and get them out of here as soon as possible." The sorcerer walks up to Vorn, slapping him on his back as he casts *Light*. "Please stop stomping for no reason."



The shield guardian nods gently as its entire body glows with a soft, purple light.

As the Party surveys the shrine, they regard the treasure-filled room. Salazar, Ariadne and Raphael inspect the closed, heavy set double door. With no keyhole or handle to open it, the trio sees only the following message carved into the stonework: *Whoever among you is the richest, bring me your gifts.*

Ariadne produces a gold piece. "Is this enough?"

The gold piece drops onto the floor, rolling away. The elven wizard chases after it, stumbling into the dark.

"Uh, technically, I'm the richest," Raphael says.

"Okay it sounds like maybe we should collect the coins here," Salazar suggests. "And put it here - "

"You can go ahead," Raphael says. The sorcerer furrows his brow as he slowly inspects the raised marble altar, above the mosaic tiles depicting a frog-like humanoid.

"Maybe we should just cast *Knock,*" Ariadne offers. "Do you have it prepared, High Mage?"

Salazar produces his spell-book and looks through it quickly. "Uh... I think I swapped it out. It might be in another book."

"Oh," Ariadne says. "Should we... physically knock?" The elven wizard steps up and knocks. Nothing happens.

Thoughtfully, Raphael steps up and places one platinum piece on the marble altar.

Intelligence (Arcana) Check
On a successful DC **15** check, Raphael, Vilde and Salazar senses divination magic scan over the marble altar, as if trying to detect the offering. They also feel illusory magic radiating all over from the treasure.

"Mmmhmm," Salazar says. "What did I say?" He hugs an amphora, bringing the entire vase over. The wizard sinks his hand into the pile of coins, fishing out a gold piece.

As he approaches, the doors open with a soft *hiss*. Looking in, the Party sees nothing but swirling darkness.

"It's Hazel's addition to the shrine," Raphael realizes. "The *Hallow* spell. Wukong!"

Having been skulking in the corner admiring the paintings, the paladin heads over. His eyes ignite with fiery light as Wukong casts *Truesight*. He quickly describes what he sees in the room: a puzzle cube with a frog carved on one of its face on a stone pedestal.

"Okay," Salazar says. "Just guide me in gently." The wizard's eyes glow softly as he summons a spectral hand.

Slowly, all of you watch intently as Salazar's *Mage Hand* disappears into the darkness. Wukong holds Salazar's hand as the pair slowly directs the *Mage Hand* towards the puzzle cube, picking it up and pulling it out of the darkness.

You have your first puzzle cube.

Having completed their mission, Raphael, Salazar, Wukong, Ariadne, Claptrap and Vorn head out. As they step out, they realize that Hazel's *Water Walk* spell has faded. With the exception of the graceful Ariadne, the rest of the Party step into knee-high swampy water, and get ready to make their way deeper into Raya.

"And what about the grungs?" Salazar asks.

"Do you want to kill them?" asks Wukong.

"No, one of us might be able to talk to one of them," Salazar explains.

"Yeah, I don't think they are going to be a problem," Raphael says. "Forget the grungs."

Father of Firearms

"Wake up," Mason splashes water at the man, jolting him awake. "Who are you, and what do you want?"

Wang Lei, Vilde and Hazel, you are joined by Mason and Thaisha in the bell tower. All of you circle around the gunslinger, who is still Restrained by the *Web*.

"Ask her," The man spat. "She's the one who executed my unarmed brother, who surrendered by the way - "

"What?" Mason asks, shocked.

"Guys?" asks Vilde. "Support me here. Was he not trying to kill us? Shouldn't we try to kill him?"

"I agree," Hazel replies. "We were under tight time pressure," the rabbitfolk continues, turning to the assailant. "You speak so much of righteousness, for someone trying to murder us just minutes ago."

The man regards the Party. "Do what you gotta do."

"No," Mason says, stepping in between the Party and the restrained assailant. He looks to Vilde, begging in his eyes. "Explain, please."

"We don't have time for this," Vilde says. "Do you want to save my mother, or interrogate this lowly lifeform?"

The squire turns to his superior. "Is that what we are supposed to do, as knights? I signed up with the Guard because I want to be a knight. Being a knight isn't just about fighting. It's also about honour. A knight defends the innocent."

"He's certainly not innocent," Sir Wang Lei replies flatly. "He just tried to kill us."

"And so we kill him," Mason says. "For wanting to kill us because we killed his brother. And after that, the little boy that escaped, he'll want to kill us, too. He'll get his friends, and then they will try, and we will kill them, but not all of them, so whoever escapes will rise and try to kill us again. Is that what we want?" Mason turns, asking the entire group. "An endless cycle of violence, all because we killed a man without cause or provocation?"

The squire straightens himself, turning to his mentor. "I followed your example so far, Sir Wang Lei. But if you think we should execute this guy, then I am afraid you are no true knight. I will not follow you any longer."

"What do you suggest then?" Wang Lei asks. "Because we obviously can't let him go - "

"I don't know!" Mason exclaims.



"Let's calm down," Thaisha says, eyeing the prisoner. "There is a middle ground. We can resurrect his brother. Bring him back to life."

Intelligence (Arcana) Check

On a successful DC **15** check, Hazel recalls all of the spells that can bring back the dead. On a successful DC **20** check, Hazel recalls the gold costs and time limits of the spells.

"Only one would work, given how long he is dead," Hazel explains. "The *Resurrection* spell."

"The Hags didn't offer it to you because they need souls to feed the Devourer," Thaisha says slowly, realizing. "But... we can. We can get him back. If we destroy the Devourer, we free his brother's soul just like how we're planning to free the Senator. Fix what we screwed up."

"Yeah, in the meantime, we can just tie him up here, take away his weapons," Hazel suggests. "Mason can stay here, keep him secure so he doesn't call for reinforcements, and watch over him?"

Mason nods. "I'm happy to stand guard here, if that's what you think is best."

The man listens intently, staying quiet as the Party discusses. He stares at Vilde.

Wisdom (Insight) Check

On a successful DC **15** check, Vilde sees as a look of confusion on the man's face as he realizes that the Party is seriously considering helping him.

"Okay," Vilde says. "We have the potential of bringing your brother back, after we destroy the Devourer. Will you stay tied up here, until we come back to get you?"

"No," the man says plainly. "I will not be tied up here. Look here. You're putting on a great show. See, I don't know if you would really try and save my brother's soul. And I sure as hell don't know why you're even considering leaving me alive. The way I see it, the only way I can trust that you are helping me release my brother's soul is if I follow you lot around."

"You're too much of a risk," Vilde says. "You're a little dumb because you haven't had much school, but how the Devourer works is that all the souls are released if it is destroyed. I don't get to choose which souls to let go - "

"And how do I know that's what you want to do?"

"There are people we've lost, too," Vilde says.

"And why should I believe you? How do I know that's not a lie?" The man retorts.

"I just told you - "

"That doesn't mean it's not a lie," the man continues. "You can tell me anything you want."

"Look at this," Vilde rolls her eyes, turning to Mason. "He's not a man of reason. We don't negotiate with terrorists. Sometimes, when you're within a rock and a hard place, you have to choose the rock." The rogue picks up a piece of rock, throwing it at the restrained man. Mason steps in, blocking it with his shield.

"I'm not trying to kill him," says Vilde exasperatedly. "I'm just trying to knock him out, tie him here, so we can come back for him later - "

Wang Lei steps up, kneeling down to the prisoner's face. "What, would you say, is your objective?"

Wisdom (Insight) Check

On a successful DC **15** check, Wang Lei sees that the man is an unwitting pawn of the Hags. The man believes that he was the one driving the negotiation to get the power to kill the Party for the price of his soul, but Wang Lei realizes that they probably already want the Party dead anyway.

On a successful DC **20** check, Vilde and Hazel sees the same look of fear his brother - Locke - had back in the crypts under the Church as the man comes to terms with the fact that he might actually die here.

"I was contracted by the Hags to kill you," the man explains. "They gave me the know-how to build the weapons, and sent me after you."

As the man continues to talk about the deal he made, his voice a feverish rattle about the deaths he had sought to provide as penance for his brother, Hazel and Vilde exchange a silent look as they both come to the realization that the man was hell-bent on retribution because the idea of bringing his brother back had never even occurred to him as a possibility.

"I have a new proposal," the knight replies, eyeing Vilde and Hazel. "Join us on our journey. Help us to take down the Hags and destroy the Devourer, which will bring you one step closer to bringing your brother back. And..." the knight stands to his full height, patting Mason on his back. "If you try to backstab us, or screw with us in anyway, Mason here will kill you personally."

"We can't trust you fully now," Vilde replies. "Just like you can't trust us. So, Mason here will be responsible for you. Do anything funny, and he will be the last thing you see."

Mason nods firmly, taking ownership of the decision to be responsible for the man.

Charisma (Persuasion) Check

The check will be made blind, but with advantage because of the Help action.

On a successful DC **20** check, the man agrees, with the intention of stabbing the Party in the back. On a successful DC **25** check, the man agrees, although he remains wary of the Party's intentions. On a successful DC **30** check, the man is swayed by the Party's desire to help and wholeheartedly commits.

With a **natural 20,** Vilde sees that the man is committed to the Party's cause and would do anything for them to get his brother back.

"Name's Percival," the gunslinger replies, shrugging. "Like I said, I don't know why the heck you guys are doing this, but if this is what you think is wise, then so be it."

"Sign of good faith," Wang Lei says, presenting the weapons back to Percival.

Vilde eyes the gunslinger intently, and sees that, despite Percival trying to play it cool, for the first time in a long while, the Party has given the man some hope.

"Alright, here's the plan," Vilde quickly catches the gunslinger up to speed. The Probably Airbourne Party, formerly the Flying Party, will take on the shrine at the over the lava pit while the Water Party will take on the two shrines on the eastern edge of the Raya. The Party will then reconvene at the shrine just along the river bisecting the city and get ready to cross to the western side. After the quick briefing, Vilde, Wang Lei, Hazel, Thaisha and Mason suit up at the belltower as they get ready to fly to the shrine above the lava pit.

"I can't fly," Percival points out.

"Well, Mason?" Vilde asks, her eyebrow raised. "Any plans? Since you want to recruit him?"

"Uh..." the squire scratches the back of his head, his mind going a million miles an hour.

"As a knight, you've gotta make decisions and solutions, you know," the rogue chides. "You can't just ask for something and not be able to follow up."

Mason takes his *Cloak of Ravens* off, offering it to Percival.

"And what about you now?"

Mason's eyes dart back and forth as he struggles to find a solution. "I can go join the Water Party - "

"And what about your duty to supervise Percival?" Wang Lei asks.

The squire curses under his breath.

"Okay, I'll help," Hazel says. "I'll cast *Water Walk,* and the two of you can go join the rest."

"No, no, no," Wang Lei interjects. "We should have as much combatants on our side as possible. I'll tell you what, the two of us will carry you. Hang onto our legs."

A column of rock rises 200 feet above the lava. A walled ruin overgrown with palms perches on the summit. Palm trees grow in front of this squat building, and worn steps ascend to an archway that forms the entrance. Reliefs of coiled serpents flank the entrance.



Coiled along the branches of the trees, you see feathered snakes that resemble those carved into the reliefs. These are *jaculis*. They regard you with an equal mix of boredom and curiosity.

Coming up to the front of the shrine, you see a narrow passage. The walls of this rubble-strewn corridor are carved with serpents, and arrow slits are spaced along them every 5 feet. Cobwebs fill the arrow slits and hang like drapes from the corridor ceiling. Above the entrance, a stone plaque bears a cuneiform massage in Celestial. "Moa teaches us that secrets hide the truth."

The Party soars, inspecting the shrine from all angles. They find no other entry points aside from the passageway.

"Let's just stay low," Vilde offers.

"Thaisha," Wang Lei asks. "Do you mind turning into a snake and going in to survey the scene?"

The half-orc druid nods. Her body crunches unnaturally as she wildshapes into a snake, slithering into the dark. After a minute, she returns back. "There's magical darkness in there," Thaisha replies.

"You don't say," Hazel replies, exasperated.

"Maybe you can go and disable it?" offers Thaisha.

"It's fine, I think it's probably pressure plate enabled," Vilde says. "I'll just sneak in." The rogue deftly sneaks in through the passage, seeing the same thing Thaisha reported.

"Guys, it's quite dark in there," Vilde reports, laughing.

"Wait, but you're fine," Hazel points out. "If you made it all the way to the altar, that must mean there are no traps, right?"

"Okay, I'll try then," Wang Lei steps up. *The Child's Teddy Bear* glows at his side as the paladin peers into the *Darkness*.

"Wait, I'll help," Hazel says. "I can see through tremorsense."

Wang Lei and Hazel, with your combined effort of tremorsense and *Devil's Sight*, both of you are able to map out the chamber shrouded in *Darkness*.

A stone cube rests on a plain stone pedestal. Statues of tribal warriors jut out from the surrounding walls, aiming bows at the pedestal. The floor in front of the pedestal, in dizzying mosaic, is a monstrous serpent. Moss obscures much of the detail.

"There's nobody inside," Hazel explains. "Just some statues." The harregon cleric summons her duplicate, materializing it just at the edge of darkness. "Get ready, I'm going to try and yank it off." The duplicate rubs her paws together, creating a long, vine-like whip covered in thorns. She pulls the whip back and lashes it forward, seizing the puzzle cube and pulling it towards her.

As the puzzle cube leaves the surface of the pedestal. Your tremorsense picks up vibrations in the air as magical arrows manifest in all twelve archers. They release their arrows at the duplicate, who fortunately takes no damage.

As the puzzle cube flies outwards to Vilde, who is waiting outside the shrine, it dissipates in a puff of green smoke just before she catches it.

"Huh," Wang Lei remarks. "Was it an illusion?"

"Maybe it's time I talk to Saleander again," Hazel turns to Wang Lei. "Cover me, I'm going in." Hazel teleports, and switches positions with her duplicate.

The knight turns to Mason, jerking his head. The squire nods, raising his shield and walking into the passageway. As he enters the narrow passageway, the trapdoors drop out from the ground underneath him.

With superior reflexes, Vilde fires a line of *Web* to catch the squire. "Watch your step," Vilde sighs.

Mason nods apologetically at the rogue.

Inside the shrine, Hazel climbs onto the pedestal and shuts her eyes. With her tremorsense, she detects empty space behind the eastern and western wall, to which she concludes must be secret chambers. She senses no sign of life, and only cobweb and statues behind in the chamber.

Outside, through her duplicate, the cleric turns to the rest of the Party. "Guys, come in! It's safe in here." The duplicate enters the narrow passageway, drifting above the pit trap.

"Uh..." Vilde says. "I guess we can fly?"

Wang Lei enter the shrine, while the rest keep guard outside.

"There, over by the carvings," Hazel directs Wang Lei, who walks over to the eastern secret door as she uses her tremorsense to navigate blind to the western door. Pressing it gently, both doors swing open softly.

Entering the secret rooms, the torches in both rooms alight.

Wang Lei, you see a statue of a coiled serpent dominating the web-filled room. The statue is missing its head, which lies broken on the floor next to a stone cube.

Hazel, you see a similar large statue of a coiled serpent in the web-filled room. Clutched in the statue's jaws is a stone cube.

"I see a cube!" Hazel shouts over.

"Same," replies Wang Lei. "Mine's on the floor."

Hazel inspects the puzzle cube, sensing ambient illusory magic pulsing out of the cube. She heads over, checking out Wang Lei's cube.

"Only one way to find out, I guess," Wang Lei steps up and grabs the cube as Hazel grabs the other. The powerful paladin and spry harregon both leap out.

As you both land, the one in Wang Lei's hands vanish in a puff of green smoke. The one in Hazel's hands stays real as you all collect the second puzzle cube.

"Well, guess we found it," Vilde remarks. "That was easy."

"Yeah, it's true," Hazel replies. "Just one last bit of business. I need to talk to my goddess."

Leaping back in, the cleric clambers onto the pedestal. Tapping into the *Commune* spell once again, Hazel reaches out to her goddess.

Wisdom (Religion) Check

On a successful DC **25** check, there is no response. Hazel intuits that there is nothing wrong with the spell casted, and suspects that Saleander is preoccupied or busy.

She silently supplicates to the goddess, connecting to the mycelium network linking the shrine. Seeing that the *Darkness* provided too much obstruction to their pursuit of the puzzles, Hazel twists the magic of the *Hallow* spell to facilitate understanding instead. Saleander's divine magic bridges the gap, translating speech between humanoids with all other creatures inhabiting the shrines even if they do not speak a common language.

Rocky Red Wizards

Raphael, Salazar, Wukong and Ariadne, accompanied by Claptrap and Vorn, pass through the Royal Palace.

Having acquired the Party's very first puzzle cube, all of you leave Nangnang's Shrine. Caked in mud and wet with swampwater, all of you (with the exception of Ariadne) climb onshore into Raya's western quarter. As you wend your way through the Royal Palace, you see that this Palace looks incredibly abandoned. Crumbling arcades, vine-choked statues, empty plazas and buildings overgrown with banyan roots. Passing through this place is a nightmare. Streets that aren't flooded are choked with rubble, and forces all of you to keep switching around. Your winding journey brings you to the front of the Palace, to which you see is unguarded.

During your time walking, you also find a small worked tunnel descending into the earth. Muddy cart tracks wind back and forth from the entrance.

You also find a trail of some kind. Iridescent slime, like an oil spill, lead westwards.

"Should we go in?" Wukong asks.

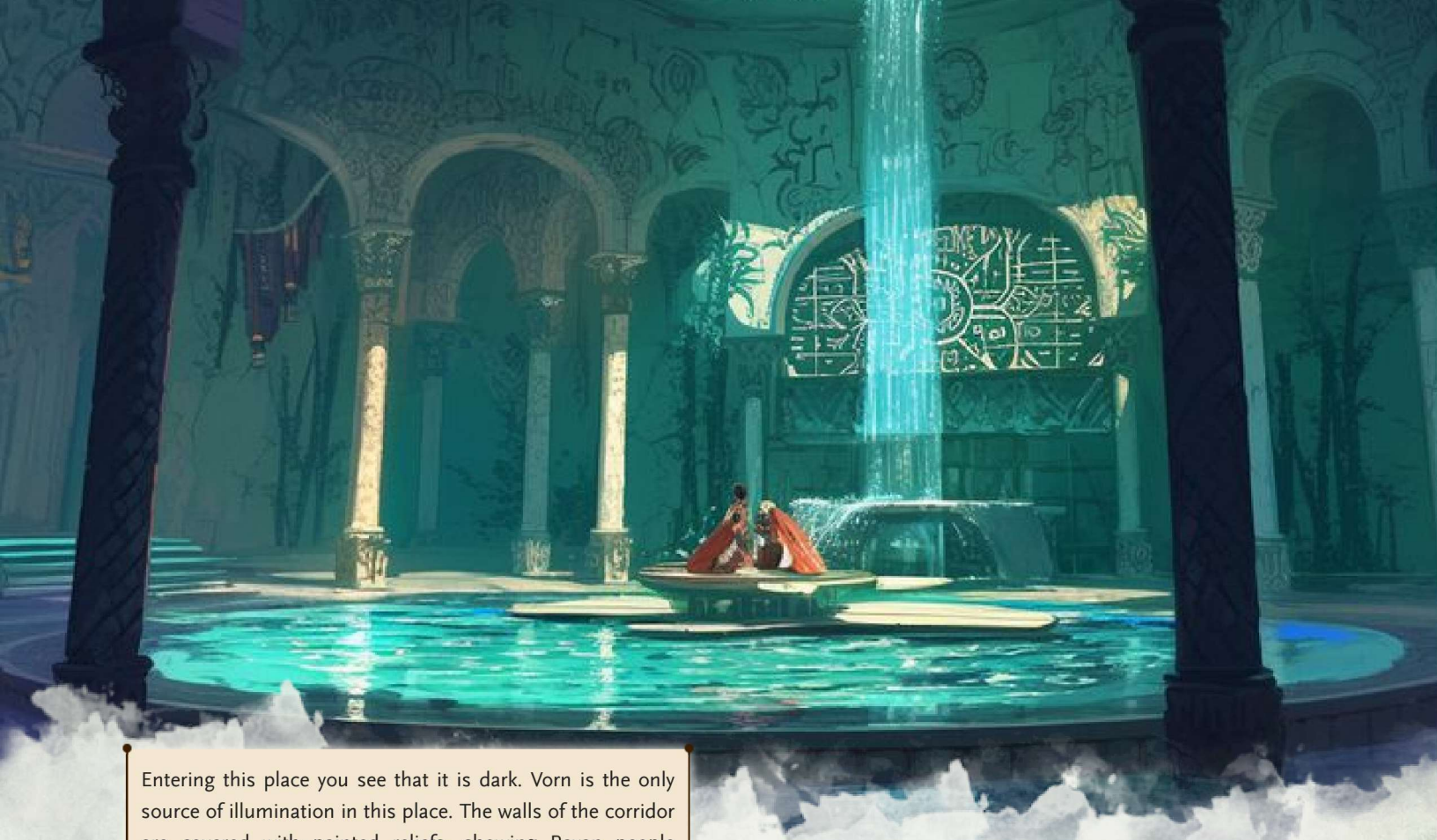
"No, we should focus on the task at hand," Raphael says. "We need the cubes. We can just take note of this, and circle back later if needed."

The Water Party presses on.

A pair of needlelike columns mark the entrance to a walled ruin. In the courtyard beyond, banyan roots envelop a squat building. The stone doors that seal the entrance are carved with images of snarling raccoons with long, sharp claws.

"Obo'laka teaches us to tread warily and stay in the light," Wukong translates the inscription over the front doors.

Raphael touches Vorn, casting *Light* on the shield guardian. Vorn breaks the door open, leading the charge. The rest of the Party follows, taking cover behind the construct.



Entering this place you see that it is dark. Vorn is the only source of illumination in this place. The walls of the corridor are covered with painted reliefs, showing Rayan people hunting, harvesting fruit, planting crops, crafting weapons, feasting, fighting, weaving, and skinning animals.

Eight empty torch brackets protrude from the walls under the reliefs.

The Party follow along the passageway, finding at its end a set of closed doors. With a simple push, the doors open into an elaborate antechamber.

A glorious sun is carved on the ceiling, directly above a pool of still water. The ceiling reflected in the pool doesn't show a sun carving, but rather a moon carving.

"I should test if the water is drinkable," Salazar offers.

"And how would you do that?" asks Raphael.

The wizard shrugs.

Ariadne surveys the pool. "This is creepy..." the elf murmurs. "Reminds me of a horror play I saw once, in Ryoko."

"Okay, I'll do it," Salazar volunteers. "Give me the *Ring*."

Ariadne tosses it over to Salazar, who catches it with one hand. The wizard puts on the *Ring*, and steps onto the cold surface of the pool. "Is something supposed to happen?" Salazar stretches his hands outwards, waiting for an effect of some kind.

"Maybe this will help," Ariadne reaches out and snatches the *Ring of Water Walking* off his finger.

Salazar drops instantly, plunging like a rock deep into the pool of water. Before his mind can even register the icy shock of the dive, his momentum inverts. The world flips on its axis as the wizard shoots out of the water, hurled through the air by his own weight. He crashes hard against the cold stone floor in an entirely new, dark room.

A full moon is carved on the ceiling here, directly above the pool. The walls are decorated with reliefs of the Rayans carrying out daily chores.

Salazar casts *Light* on himself, surveying the room.

Intelligence (Investigation) Check
On a successful DC **15** check, Salazar sees that one of the figures on the wall relief is crafting a key. On closer inspection, the key looks like a button of some kind.

Pushing the key, the secret door pops open, revealing a dusty, web-filled tunnel beyond. Eager to report his

discoveries, Salazar pops through the magical pool again to the opposite side. He quickly runs the Party through what he found, prompting the rest of the Party to follow suit and jump through the portal too.

The Party decide to explore the secret door later, opting to enter the main chamber.

> Eight torches illuminate this room. The light washes over a raised marble altar decorated with mosaic tiles showing a small racoon with sharp claws. In the middle of the room, four robed figure stands next to a waist-high pedestal, atop which rests a stone cube. The figures are bald and one of them has one hand on the cube. It takes a moment to realize that those figures are statues.



The Party decide to map out the secret passage as well. Proceeding down the web-filled tunnel, they quickly clear it out and find themselves at the end with a stone door.

> The stone door is barred from here. Three wooden planks seal it shut.

Vorn steps up, removing the wooden planks. With a light push, the stone doors swing open, leading out to the main entrance of the shrine they had just come in not long ago.

"I guess it's a quick escape route of some kind," Salazar concludes.

The Party gather back in the moon room, discussing their plan of attack.

"We should stagger ourselves," offers Raphael. "Those who are fastest should stay at the front, and after we take the cube we can run out. After you take the cube, you never know what might happen. For all we know, traps might activate."

"We could *Misty Step* out," Salazar suggests.

"Yeah, maybe," Raphael agrees. "Unless the trap results in magical darkness, then that might not be possible."

"Take and run," Wukong says. "Sounds like a plan."

"I'll *Mage Hand* the cube," Salazar decides. "Gives us all a bit more space to run."

Raphael nods. "And if anything goes down, we can just make a run out through the back."

Wukong enlarges his quarterstaff as the Party watches on intently.

Salazar's *Mage Hand* creeps forward, slowly into the center of the room. Its spectral, incorporeal fingers close around the puzzle cube and lift it from its pedestal.

> As your Mage Hand lifts the cube off the pedestal, Salazar give me a DC **15** Constitution saving throw.
>
> Failing the Constitution saving throw, you feel the effects of a petrification curse pass over you. You become rooted to the ground as your feet turn to stone.
>
> As the curse transfers over to you, all of you watch the four statues animate and come to life. As the magic that turns them to stone fade from their bodies, you recognize them: bald heads, red robes. These are Red Wizards.

Salazar pulls the cube towards him. Vorn steps forward, tapping the wizard on his shoulder. The mute shield guardian mimes the action of passing him the cube.

Eager to pass on the petrification, Salazar tosses the cube over to Vorn. The shield guardian resists the curse, as he cannot be petrified.

"We need to kill them," Raphael points out. "While they are petrified!"

Vorn lumbers forward. The shield guardian viciously swings on one of the Red Wizards, who is still in the midst of unpetrification. He lands hefty blows in the abdomen of the stone-faced wizard, who opens his eyes just in time to watch the shield guardian break him into smithereens. As the Red Wizard regains his movement and stumbles backwards, desperately tryinng to keep his innards from spilling onto the ground, Wukong surges from the darkness and completes the job. The paladin swings his quarterstaff and bisects the lich.

All of Raphael's eyes glow with a malevolent purple light as a web of black tentacles erupt around the unpetrifying wizards, restraining them.

Identifying Raphael as the spellcaster restraining them, the leader of the Red Wizards threaten, "I don't need to move to kill you."

As they begin to cast *Cloudkill,* Raphael and Salazar seize the opportunity to *Counterspell.* The sorcerer slaps one of the spells out of the air, but the wizard fails to stop the others. Noxious, yellow gas explodes from two points beside Raphael, flooding the shrine. As the sorcerer breathes it in, the gas finds the moisture in his lungs and converts it. Burning acid begins to melt the lining of his throat and eyes. His vision blurs into a red, tearing haze, as a dry, hacking cough rips through his chest.

Salazar and Ariadne also begin to suffocate as the poisonous gas tries to drown them in their own bodies. They double over, gasping for air that isn't there. Claptrap, unaffected, wheels forward to the pair. His eyes glow blue as the warforged medic casts *Cure Wounds* on Ariadne, healing the elf.

The wizard stumbles forward, desperate to get out of the gas. As he breaks out of the cloud, Salazar casts *Fireball.* One of the Red Wizard seizes the opportunity to *Counterspell,* cancelling the *Fireball.*

Vorn focuses his effort on the Red Wizards, intent on neutralizing them. With no effort two of the construct's arms seize one of the Red Wizard, lifting the spellcaster up by his neck. The shield guardian wordlessly crushes the Red Wizard's skull, dropping his lifeless body on the ground. He continues to slam into the other Red Wizard, pulverising his ribcage and breaking his concentration.

As the *Cloudkill* spell fades, the gas dissipates. Ariadne, through racking coughs, fires a *Guiding Bolt* at the Red Wizards, striking one of them square in the chest.

"Let's finish this," Raphael says. Striding forward, the sorcerer drops the *Web* spell and casts *Hold Person.* The writhing mass of tentacles coalesces into two massive appendages which slither around the two surviving liches and immoblizes them.

Wukong executes one of the Red Wizards as Salazar closes distance with the last survivor.

"Do you know where your other compatriots are?"

The Red Wizard, hate in his eyes, nods.

"Which shrine?"

He opens his mouth to speak, but the tentacle, tight around his neck, prevents movement.

"Do you have other cubes?" asks Ariadne.

The Red Wizard nods.

"Okay, good to know," the elven wizard fires another *Guiding Bolt*, destroying the undead spellcaster.

Croak and Fragger

Following their success at Moa's Shrine, the Probably Airbourne Party soars to the shrine by the river.

As the sun sets, swirly carvings decorate two obelisks at the entrance to this compound. An overgrown courtyard lies under the shade of tall palms. Open stone doors to a windowless shrine greets you as you land here in the courtyard.

To your left, you see that there is a smaller ruin. The roof of this workshop has collapsed long ago, with a thick mass of plants growing from the rubble. Through the moss, you see hundreds of iron keys hanging from hooks on the wall. Some are bent and broken, while others are rusted beyond repair. The rest look relatively serviceable.

Entering the shrine, you see a statue of a giant snail looming over you all. In place of antennae, it has five pseudopods ending in rocky clubs. Along the walls, five iron keys hang in small niches above stone plinths. Behind the statue, a carved pedestal in a wide alcove has a keyhole set into its base, with a key already inserted.



"Puzzle cube's gone," Wang Lei remarks. "Guess we can set up for camp, instead?"

Hazel kneels down in front of the pedestal, praying. Seeking to *Commune* with the goddess, Hazel finds no reply once again. The cleric patiently waits in silent prayer, hoping for a connection of some kind.

As Mason and Thaisha start to set up the Party's tent, Percival comes up to Vilde and Wang Lei.

"I understand that this is the beginning of a... tenuous relationship. I am happy to provide a gesture of good faith," Percival says. "I spotted you, while you were circling around the city, and I alerted the Hags. They were the ones that gave me the go-ahead to attack you. They know you are here. And, I don't know if you are familiar with them, but the Hags are... masters at nightmares. That's how they got into contact with me, at first. They induced horrible dreams in me. They will know that I have turned against them. And they will not hesitate to attack us."

Nightmare Haunting

Every time the Party Long Rests, the Hags will attack the Party through their *Nightmare Haunting* ability. The three of them casts *Dream* as a Coven, heightening their spell. On a successful DC **15** Wisdom saving throw, no effect happens; on a failed save, the target takes 3d6 Psychic damage and has their hit point maximum reduced by that amount. They also do not gain the benefit of Rest.

"The good news is, there's only three of them. The bad news is, they seem particularly interested in you," Percival jerks his head at Sir Wang Lei. "And uh, the wizard with the stupid name. Sam? Or was it Salvatore?"

"Yeah, something like that," Vilde smirks.

"How are you communicating with them?"

"Letters, but mostly I wait for them to instruct me," Percival replies. "They come to me in my dreams. They have the ability to see through my eyes, somehow."

{"Something about you serving the Atropal?" Percival explains. "I'm not too sure, to be honest."}

Arriving at Unkh's Shrine, Vilde and Wang Lei hear them before seeing them. Covered in bandages and wounds, Raphael and Wukong lead the Water Party's complaint about their exhausting day.

The Party reunites as Vilde surveys the group, laughing at their misfortune. They catch each other up on their day quickly.

Seeing a newcomer in the group, Salazar introduces himself to Percival.

"Wait, who's he?" Raphael asks.

"He tried to kill us, but it was the Hags that instructed him to do so," Vilde explains. "He thinks we killed his brother - "

"I *know* you killed my brother - "

"Please stop," Vilde insists.

"Is he related to the boy who sniped us?" asks Raphael.

"Actually, his brother was the spotter," Vilde continues. "He was the attacker."

"Right," Raphael says, eyeing Percival suspiciously.

"He's not really my brother," Percival continues. "But yeah, I should probably try and find him."

"To be fair, you pushed him into the river," Vilde points out.

"Well, yeah, because I thought you were going to kill me!" Percival says. "You know what, it's fine. I'll send him a message." The gunslinger produces a *Sending* stone and starts speaking into it.

"We need to be careful sleeping," Wang Lei says. "The Hags know we're here." He briefs them quickly about their ability to haunt their dreams.

The Party discusses a possible plan to protect against the haunting, including cuddling with Wukong for the protective aura.

Intelligence (Arcana) Check

On a successful DC **15** check, Salazar shares that *Protection from Good and Evil* might be able to prevent the Hag's attacks.

"Should we compare notes?" Vilde asks, to sighs from Raphael. "How were your shrines?"

"It was a tough day!" Ariadne says. "How many did you guys get?"

"We only got one," Vilde produces Moa's Puzzle Cube, showing it to the Party. "We got here early, but it looks like the shrine has already been emptied out."

"We got two!" Ariadne says chirpily. "Not that it's a competition - "

"Oh by the way," Salazar points to Obo'laka's Puzzle Cube in Vorn's hands. "You all see that cube ah, don't go and touch please. See no touch, touch no see. Unless you want to become a stone like me."

Ariadne and Raphael exchange looks, before Ariadne speaks up, "Yeah, that's true."

As the Party prepares to settle in for the night, Wang Lei approaches Raphael to pull him to a corner. Salazar spots them moving away and decides to stealthily follow along, suspicious of the pair. They spot him, however, and move out of the tent to have the private conversation.

"I think my patron is insisting that I put the amulet into Salazar's belongings," Wang Lei begins. "Given that you didn't find anything wrong with it..."

Raphael raises an eyebrow. "It hasn't even been a day since I had it."

"Shall we wait a night?" Wang Lei offers. "And if there's nothing wrong, we can just slip it into his belongings."

"Wait," Raphael says slowly. "You're serious?"

Wang Lei nods gravely. "I'm saying this because my patron won't speak to me, not until we do this."

The sorcerer stays quiet, inspecting the warlock. "Before I decide whether to hand this necklace back to you... I have something I want to ask you. Back in Camp Vengeance as we were interrogating the Senator's assassin, you said that 'Harondus had something against me.' What exactly does he have against me?"

"The way I understand it is that he doesn't like your family," Wang Lei explains. "Politics."

"Show me," Raphael says. "Let me look into your mind."

The warlock nods. Raphael casts *Detect Thoughts,* peering into the mind of Wang Lei. He watches the entire conversation between them play out in the dining room, carefully studying each moment.

> I think that Raphael sees Harondus's focus on House Antarra and the secret source of their powers.

As the vision ends, Raphael realizes that Wang Lei revealed to the Inspector that the source of his sorcerous power is from an elder god of some kind.

Raphael rubs his eyebrows, calculating. "This is a secret closely guarded by my family. It relates to my family's survival. And yet you've revealed it..." The sorcerer's voice trails off. "Although you didnt really have much of a choice. He had you under *Zone of Truth.*"

"Yeah," Wang Lei replies. "In fact, I almost swung my mace at him." The warlock thinks for a moment, before continuing, "Actually, maybe I should hold the necklace. It's dangerous for you to hold it, right? I can cast *Protection from Good and Evil* on myself, and thus be shielded from its effects."

The sorcerer nods, producing the necklace and handing it back to the warlock. The pair returns into the tent.

Realizing that Wang Lei and Raphael is aware of his presence, Salazar heads off to find Vilde. He pulls her aside privately in the stable, sharing his suspicions.

"Do you remember our conversation last night?" Salazar asks. "About... who I might be?"

"Yes, yes," Vilde replies. "Acererak, right?"

"I'm not Acererak," Salazar corrects the rogue. "I'm Acererak's clone." He chews his lips, hesitating. "This morning, I saw Wang Lei and Raphael sneak off and have a conversation. I overheard them talking about how they have an amulet that is supposed to be given to me. And then, I just saw them head out again, trying to have another secretive conversation." The wizard's eyes find the rogue's, worry in his eyes. "I suspect that they might be plotting something against me. What do you think I should do?"

"Have you asked them directly?" asks Vilde.

"No," Salazar replies. "They're not supposed to know that I know, because you know, I sneaked up on them."

"I feel like you spying on them is a lesser crime than them potentially trying to kill you," Vilde says plainly.

"You think I should approach them?" Salazar says.

"Yes," Vilde says plainly. "I think you should just ask them directly. Who knows? You might even recognize the amulet as something from your past."

Salazar stays quiet. “Yeah, I do want to take this omulet from them.”

“What’s an omulet?”

“Amulet,” Salazar corrects himself. “Do you think you can help me get it? I know you’re a proficient thief - “

The rogue raises an eyebrow. “You want me to take it for you secretly? Isn’t that kind of going against my advice of talking to them about it?”

“I will,” Salazar says. “But if it doesn’t work out...”

Vilde nods. “If that doesn’t work out, you can tell me and I’ll you take it.”

Salazar returns to his room, collecting his thoughts. Working up his courage, the wizard heads off to find Wang Lei.

“Don’t mind me,” Salazar says. “I saw previously you were talking to Raphael about an amulet of some kind, and I overheard my name. Do you mind telling me more about the amulet? How is it related to me?”

“I cannot tell you anything,” Wang Lei says plainly. “And to be honest, I don’t know actually. But let me just tell you this. I can cast *Protection from Good and Evil* on you, so nothing bad will happen to you.”

Salazar scrutinizes the warlock’s face, but finds nothing.

“I specifically heard that this amulet is meant for me,” Salazar continues. “And then you passed it to Raphael? Is that supposed to protect me?”

“No, no,” Wang Lei explains. “I will be the one that protects you.”

“Then why did you pass it to Raphael?”

“It was to help me check,” Wang Lei explains. “He is much better at these arcane matters than me, and I wanted to see if there was anything special about the amulet - “

“And what did he say?”

“He said there was nothing that concerns us,” Wang Lei replies.

“Okay, I will take your word for it,” The wizard replies. “To be frank, I am quite scared of what I will become. If you know of any truth about what is to come, or who I am, you have to let me know - “

“I cannot,” Wang Lei says. “But I am not here to harm you.”

Salazar nods. Still suspicious of the warlock, and knowing that he will gain no further answers here, the wizard heads off to find Raphael.

“Yo, Raphael,” Salazar enters the sorcerer’s room, shutting the door behind him. “I know that this is on me, and that I shouldn’t be sneaking around, but I did see you pass an amulet to Wang Lei outside the tent. Does that concern me? He was being a bit dodgy when I questioned him about it.”

“Your past is also dodgy,” Raphael replies. “Don’t you know that?”

“I do,” Salazar replies. “That’s why I’m trying to figure out how is this amulet related to me.”

“I think for the safety of everybody,” Raphael offers. “We should all just come clean and try to seek answers together as a Party - “

“I couldn’t agree more,” Salazar asks. “That’s why I shared about the dream I had with Acererak.”

“I think we are similar, you know,” Raphael says, looking at the wizard. “Despite our differences, we can both potentially harm the Party. We are going to fight the person that created you, so I think it’s natural that people are going to have their guard around you. But regarding my conversation with Wang Lei... that is not my secret to tell.”

Salazar stays quiet, thinking. He sees Wang Lei’s insistence at protecting the secret, and suspects that perhaps the warlock is in a difficult position and cannot reveal what he knows. Salazar thanks the sorcerer before heading off politely.

The wizard does not return to his room. Instead, he heads to Vilde’s, who raises an eyebrow at Salazar’s approach.

“I’ve spoken to both of them,” Salazar says, steeling himself. “I’m going to need your help.”